

FESTIVE SPIRIT
Jagan Mohan Reddy with his wife Y.S. Bharathi Reddy at Tadepalli in Vijayawada on Makar Sankranti (January 14)

in August 2020 had to be put on hold because the Union government prohibits changes in boundaries of villages and towns once the national census has been announced. But with the pandemic-induced delay in conducting the census and the Centre easing the ban on reorganisation till July, the YSRCP government is eager to fast-track the formation of new districts.

Several districts will have thoughtfully chosen names. The one headquartered in Vijayawada is named N.T. Rama Rao, founder of the Telugu Desam Party (TDP). Three others also have a wide appeal—Sri Balaji for the Tirupati-Tirumala temple region, Annamayya district after the 15th century Hindu saint Tallapaka Annamacharya, and the Puttaparthi-headquartered Sri Satya Sai district after the godman. There is also Alluri district after the illustrious freedom fighter Alluri Seetharama Raju. There are demands to rename existing districts too. Some want Kurnool to be named after Damodaram Sanjeevaiah, India's first Dalit chief minister. Others want Ananthapuram to be renamed after former president Neelam Sanjeeva Reddy. Protests have begun for changing the proposed district headquarters and inclusion of areas in one or the other district.

Even as the state government reviews suggestions and works to resolve objections by February, the emerging challenge is to raise resources to develop infrastructure for so many new district headquarters. It's undoubtedly a financial burden on the cash-strapped state. However, it also enables Jagan Reddy to provide decentralised development in an equitable manner and arguably reap dividends in the assembly election in 2024. ■

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New districts proposed in Andhra Pradesh, taking total to 26

24
of 25 Lok Sabha seats will become a revenue district after the reorganisation

Largest district
Prakasam (14,322 sq. km)

Most populous
Kurnool (2.36 mn people)